

60 times smaller in size. "Staying alert about its breeding places, such as small holes, damp walls and areas like *gaushalas* (cow shelters) is the only way to save ourselves," she says.

"I have seen people run from pillar to post for treatment. And that leads to a lot of suffering and wastage of money. The treatment itself is simple if we get in touch with the district health officials and doctors. You don't need to go to private hospitals either because government hospitals are equipped to cure it," Pinki adds. She is hoping to become a social worker in the future, adding that half of Purvanchal's problems would be solved if the health and education infrastructure saw improvement.

According to a World Health Organization (WHO) report, people of UP, Bihar, Jharkhand and West Bengal are at risk in India, where cases have been recorded in 54 districts of these states where the disease is endemic. Deoria, Kushinagar, Ballia and Ghazipur districts are the hotspots in UP. India has pledged to eliminate the disease by the end of 2023 although the WHO is hoping to achieve the same result globally only by the end of 2030.

Pinki says she began her campaign against the disease from her own college, the Babban Singh Intermediate College in Ratasiya village of Deoria district. Having got positive feedback, in July, she started visiting schools and local communities. Till date, she has been able to reach out to over 10,000 children across several schools in Deoria. Pinki is now planning visits to schools in other nearby districts. The National Vector Borne Disease Control Programme (NVBDCP), the central nodal agency for prevention and control of vector-borne diseases, has also officially praised her contribution in spreading awareness against the dreaded Kala Azar. ■

A Shade Better

***Happiness delivery:** Forest First has not only helped restore native plant species in the Western Ghats but has also improved the lives of local communities*

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**

After 16 years of working at Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) in Wayanad, Kerala, it was a 2010 visit to a piece of land Meera Chandran's family owned in the district that changed her life. She found that Lantana weed, an invasive species that kills native plants, had taken over the land, thereby upsetting the ecological balance. For three years, Chandran worked tirelessly—manually uprooting the weeds so that they don't grow back—to clear the area and restore native plant species. Around the same time, the endeavour made Chandran want to work on conservation on a larger scale, and thus, the Forest First Samithi was born. After four years of juggling TCS and Forest First, she finally quit her job and devoted her entire time to conservation.

"Forest First was started with a vision to conserve a large diversity of native tree species, including rare, endangered and threatened flora, by restoring lands that are degraded by exotic invasive species," says Chandran.

FOREST FIRST SAMITHI
FOUNDED: 2010
Wayanad, Kerala

Since its